

The menu navigation is easy enough. However, the device exits the menu as soon as you view or change an option—very irritating if you need to change two or more options. Operating the device is simple if you are carrying it around your neck, but if it's inside your pocket, you'll have to remove it to access the controls.

The supplied headphones are comfortable, but with below average audio output—there was no difference in sound quality using our reference headphones either. The bass and treble levels of the Hindi track were distorted—the vocals were too sharp and not up to the mark. The data transfer was very fast, taking 1 minute 35 seconds for the 50 MB set of MP3 files.

Its sub Rs 9,000 price and funky looks will make it an attractive buy for teenagers, but it is not a product for serious music buffs. Its average audio quality, poor battery life, bad build quality and poor software need to be considered before buying the BP300.

- + Good set of headphones
- + Fast data transfer
- Poor application support
- No playlist and folder support
- Average audio quality
- Poor battery life

Price: Rs 8,990

Apacer Audio Steno BP300 B	
Performance	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Features	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Value for money	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Ease of use	■ ■ ■ ■ ■

Creative Digital MP3 Player LX100

Top of the charts

The LX100 plays MP3 and WMA audio, has voice recording as well as FM radio. A small and lightweight device, it is extremely portable and can be carried inside your pocket or around your neck. It sports a metallic silver finish and a large backlit LCD. The screen displays song file-names, folders, menu settings, battery status, audio format, playing mode, chosen equalizer mode and even a visualiser. A jog switch controls playback functions and menu settings. Other buttons on the device include a volume and record, play, hold, repeat, and other mode buttons. The play button doubles as an on and off switch.

When connected to the PC running Windows 98 SE and above via the USB port, it is recognised as a removable drive. You can use Windows Explorer to copy files to and from the device. The 128 MB flash memory is non-upgradeable. The internal lithium-ion battery is automatically recharged when connected to a USB port. The battery lasts for 10 hours of continuous play, just as the manufacturer claims.

The 128 MB (or 24 MP3s encoded at 160 Kbps) capacity may not be enough to last over the weekend, but will easily last through your daily commute or morning jogging sessions. You can create a playlist and organise songs inside appropriately named folders. There's no ID3 support, which results in just the file-name scrolling across the LCD display.

Apart from standard repeat and playback functions, you can choose from five equaliser modes, as well as adjust bass and treble as per your choice. FM reception is average, and you can scan for available channels—you can store ten

channels as favourites. You can record voice or radio for up to 8 hours. This is useful if you are interviewing someone, as the clarity is good and you can transfer the recording to your PC. There is no software bundled, the accompanying CD only contains drivers for Windows 98 SE, and warranty and support information.

The LX100's menu is well designed, but the haphazard button placement leaves much to be desired. The bundled headphones are a little too sharp, but the quality of sound we heard with our reference headset was very good. The audio output has good treble, mids and vocals, but the bass is a tad weak. It took almost 2 minutes (1 minute 56 seconds) to transfer the 50 MB set of MP3s.

Overall, the LX100 is a portable, light-weight and feature-rich device with good quality audio output. Considering its features, a price of Rs 9,799 is very good. Thus, it scored well in both the features, as well as the value for money sections, which paved the way to its crown as the winner of our test.

- + Decent set of features
- + Easy installation
- + Large LCD
- No bundled software

Price: Rs 9,799

Creative Digital MP3 Player LX100 A-	
Performance	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Features	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Value for money	■ ■ ■ ■ ■
Ease of use	■ ■ ■ ■ ■

Creative Nomad MuVo 64MB

Back to the basics

With a two-piece design, the Nomad MuVo is similar to the Apacer Audio Steno—it can be directly plugged into a USB port. The device features a white removable USB memory stick that slides into a blue-coloured module with the battery compartment. The memory module has playback buttons and a two-colour LED on the front, with volume controls and a repeat button on one side. The unit is lightweight and about the size of a cigarette lighter. The device supports MP3 and WMA formats, and also doubles up as a removable storage device offering up to 64 MB of storage space. However, other features such as voice recording, FM tuner or an LCD screen are conspicuously absent.

To transfer music to the player, all you need to do is remove the memory stick from the unit and plug it into the USB port of your computer. No cables or drivers are required for Win Me, 2000, or XP, and it is automatically recognised as a removable drive. You can use Windows Explorer to transfer files to and from the device. Bundled software includes drivers for Windows 98 SE and a formatting utility. The device only plays MP3 and WMA files stored in the root, and not those stored in folders.

The controls allow you to scroll through the stored tracks, play, pause, control volume and repeat whole tracks, or a particular section of a track. There are no equaliser modes or any other playback features. You cannot view track information, as there is no LCD display. When the battery is low, the LED blinks red. Powered by a single AAA battery, the MuVo gave us almost 11 hours of continuous playback. Most people will find the 64 MB memory capacity insufficient.

Controlling the device is literally child's play, due to good

